

A viral aesthetic. An industrial fish farm. The evaluation instruments of a research lab. Over the past three years I have worked on projects with very little in common. One question, even so, has kept returning. What remains of the encounter between a designed device and its public? And who takes responsibility for documenting its traces?

These questions tend to surface only when a project is over, as a check on whether it worked. I have learned instead to treat the recording of what happens between artefact and public as part of the work itself. How that encounter is recorded is, in effect, what decides what the project will be able to say about itself, to whom, and for how long.

Targeted Action 3 closes on two outcomes that depend on one another: a public assembly, and a document setting out evaluation criteria for artistic practices in research. The document can only be written out of what the assembly produces, and what is left of the assembly depends entirely on what has been prepared in advance to record it.

Designing those instruments is the task I intend to take on.

The call asks for an archive able to preserve the vitality of its materials without neutralising them. That is a problem of form before it is a problem of preservation. Sánchez Criado and Estalella set the activity of inventorying apart from museum conservation, which is focused on what Fernando Domínguez Rubio terms ‘caring for the same’, whereas ‘inventorying means caring for the singular’. That is the posture I take. I design the archive as a register of singular voices, not as a repository that sorts them into categories decided before they arrive.

What belongs in an inventory cannot be settled in advance – a recording, a collected object, a mark left on a sheet of paper. Each material poses three decisions: whether to include it; how much of its provenance to include with it; what is needed for it to be reopened. A material that keeps its provenance attached to it can still be contradicted by the person who produced it. This is where it is decided whether a material holds on to its dignity or turns into data.

The last of these falls to whoever builds the device; its consequences are inherited by whoever receives the materials later. During my internship at the DensityDesign Lab of the Politecnico di Milano I was on the receiving side: I digitised and visualised the evaluation spaces of the eight projects in the exhibition Stream, Beef, Vibes, four of them mine and four handled by a fellow intern. AI-timetria came out of that internship – a protocol that turns visitors’ pen marks into contour lines.

The group running the AI Slop inquiry had asked participants to mark in pen the differences between two frames of the same AI-generated video. No method had been planned for getting from a marked area back to the object it corresponded to, and the results were initially declared inconclusive. I approached the problem from the other end. Rather than starting from the objects and asking how often each had been chosen – the question the collected material could not answer – I started from the marks. Each pen-marked area was isolated and overlaid on the others like contour lines.

The original frame is laid back on top only at the end, and the objects emerge from the frequency of the marks rather than being presupposed by it: the centre of the table, marked twenty times; the television stand, marked fifteen. The data are the ones originally collected. Only the form in which they are shown has changed. The new reading interrogates the marks as a body rather than one at a time, and the clustering it produces was already a property of the material. What changed is not the preservation of the material, but the form that makes it interrogable.

An archive that can be activated on a field site as much as at the Institut Transform has to work where no dedicated technical department is available. Whoever designs it must therefore be able to build and handle it directly. I build interfaces in React and Three.js, write the Python pipelines that feed them, and work with electronics. For NJÖRD I built the steel console through which the public configures the colour of its own farmed salmon: interface and physical implementation. I have also worked in situated display – an installation for Stream, Beef, Vibes and digital sculptures shown at MEET in Milan.

(The assembly as a device)

The public assembly can be set up as the moment at which conclusions are presented, or on the logic of what Marcus calls a para-site: an event designed to sit alongside the field rather than after it, whose purpose is mutual concept work with the people the inquiry concerns. Marcus's para-sites are small and invited; a public assembly is neither, and what has to be transposed is the protocol, not the format. It is the second sense I intend to take on.

If the assembly generates no material, the document has nothing to stand on. Direct questions return what their own frame allows. Building the criteria document out of those answers would confirm the opening question instead of testing it. Alongside them a second device is needed, one that hands the participants a task: an operation – ordering, categorising, marking, arranging – whose outcome cannot be anticipated.

In Not clean enough the evaluation area collected no judgements. It handed the visitor a set of uncategorised comments and asked them to apply to it the same constructive logic as the visualisation. The device put the categorisation to the test, making it contestable by the people who had not built it. This is the route I would bring into the assembly: what Cantarella, Hegel, and Marcus call a 'zone of disputation', where misalignment is not noise but result.

That misalignment is the material the document has to be written from, and it survives only in a form built to hold it: a form that asks to be answered with a description, or one that asks for a score to be aggregated. What remains open to dispute once the evaluation is over depends on which. If two evaluators agree in describing an artefact, they are looking at the same aspect of it, and the evaluation confirms rather than discovers.

When they diverge, each makes perceptible an element that escapes the other. Making that difference explicit produces a criterion that can be put back as a question. Aggregating the two descriptions into a single score yields an apparent conclusion instead. The Multimodal Appreciation kit, which Sánchez Criado also co-authored, proceeds in the same way: every value is formulated as a question, and the responses are written separately and side by side, since '[t]he point is to bring each response to each question into a visible relationship' rather than to aggregate them into a score.

The kit's three traditional academic values – originality and relevance, communication, truth value – are not abandoned but extended beyond the text, and set alongside values they cannot register on their own. To the document I do not intend to bring criteria already defined, but the material from which to derive them. I know what the alternative costs: my bachelor's thesis built four matrices out of the perceptions of 286 visitors at the Raw Scenarios exhibition, reduced each judgement to a score and the scores to an average – closing the reading exactly where it should have opened it.

(Requirements not yet met)

I work in English without difficulty, in writing and in speech. My French is at a more elementary level, and I state it as such. I am following a structured course and working towards the DELF B2 by May 2027 – the level the assemblies and the work with field actors require.

I do not come from the environmental sciences, but a question about representation has run through my studies from the start. I met it studying semiotics, and I have taken it up, each time, in disciplinary fields other than my own. Targeted Action 3 starts from the premise that environmental crises are, first of all, crises of representation. That premise is where I enter the project.

Gestures of transformation in a Laboratoire Terrestre arise in situations whose perimeter I do not set. 'When you change the scale of your representation,' Latour writes, 'you immediately render yourself sensitive to new phenomena.' So far I have made that change downstream, on materials already collected. In the field it is made as the situation unfolds. That is the passage I expect to learn.

At the Digital Methods Initiative, University of Amsterdam, I worked alongside sociologists and anthropologists, facilitating the groups and designing the posters through which each opened its results to comment by those who had not produced them. Entering an inquiry not your own forces you to work out what that discipline counts as a result, before deciding what form will hold it.